13 Assessments in the Design Studio

Self-Reflecting on MDD (AUAS) Methods

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Introduction

As a format for design education, the 'studio model' is rooted in the practice of the architectural studio. When taking part in studio-model education, design students are typically proposed a project in the form of a brief, often involving external organisations that play the role of the client. These briefs can be highly prescriptive, or they can be open-ended, leaving more space for student's initiatives and interests (Giloi & Belluigi, 2017). The complexity of projects tends to increase as students advance in their studies and form the basis of the tacit knowledge needed for professional practice.

In the most traditional end of the design studio, the performance of students is assessed by tutors who guide the creative process and help students navigate the brief and their relation to the client in a mix of formative and summative assessments. However, with the increasing integration of design schools to universities and the development of educational policies and standards applying to all fields, this model of assessment is increasingly challenged. The challenges of traditional studio assessment do not only result from the organisational changes mentioned previously, but also from internal debates in the field.

Some design educators defend the value of this model given the particularities of creative education and professional practice (Orr & Bloxham, 2013). Moreover, they argue for their authenticity in connecting students with 'real world' issues and positioning them in the role of a professional practitioner from their first design experience, following a learning-by-doing approach (Axelsson, Eriksson, & Wideström, 2006; Taylor & McCormack, 2004). Others argue that it promotes an outdated designer profile, with a "superficial understanding of the problems they are presented with (…), treating the symptoms rather than the underlying root causes" (Meyer & Norman, 2020). Another downside mentioned in literature is the

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obscurity of traditional studio-based assessment practices, where the principles of reliability, validity, and transparency are difficult to put in practice (Karahanoğlu, Alink, & Bakırlıoğlu, 2019). Yet another shortcoming mentioned by design scholars is the resulting isolation and marginalisation of creative disciplines from the other fields (Wang, 2010), hindering interdisciplinary collaboration, academic mobility, and the consolidation of design as an academic discipline.

Research has found that that too much importance is given to the product in assessment practices of creative disciplines (de la Harpe et al., 2009) and that a stronger focus on process and person is needed. Although products or portfolios are often used to evaluate the design process too, how this happens is not necessarily made explicit to students. An explicit focus on how the student works during assessment has been assigned the "potential to redirect the learner toward reflection and understanding" (Ehmann, 2004).

Assessments are not only moments of evaluation but are also functional to learning because students consider how they will be assessed during curricular activities. Moreover, assessments foster retrospective reflection from students on what they achieved. A good alignment between assessments and learning objectives, focusing on reflection, evaluation, and improvement can upgrade design education to ensure long term learning and transparency in the objectives it pursues, while acknowledging the importance of tacit knowledge. However, there is no single or validated way to do this, as developing the tools and procedures to do it remains a challenge (Whelan, Maher, & Deevy, 2017).

This chapter discusses how we at the master of science (M.Sc.) in Digital Design (MDD), a one-year programme at the Amsterdam University of Applied Sciences (AUAS), have dealt with these issues from the vantage point of a newly established curriculum, set up in 2017. Based on a survey distributed among graduates and former assessors of the programme, we reflect on how the methods used respond to the intentions for their development. These intentions include addressing some of the challenges of design studio assessments mentioned in literature. By asking assessment participants for a comparative perspective between these and other assessment methods they have experienced in an international design education context, we engage in a self-reflective process with the purpose of improving the programme's evaluation tools. In this chapter, we share this self-reflective study with others that are also committed to find better assessment tools for design education.

In comparison to other subjects such as STEM, design education has been a somewhat neglected area of education research. Hounsell et al. (2007) for example identified 272 published articles that were categorised as appropriate to the topic of Innovative Assessment Across the Disciplines, of which only six fell under the category "art, design and media". Ehmann (2005) assigns this gap to the non-standard procedures and methods in the design education, highlighting assessment as a significantly neglected area. In this study, we contribute to a more active academic discussion about design education that has emerged in the last decade, as visible in the papers referenced previously. Although the chapter focuses on our own practices as a programme, it is not intended to promote the choices we have made or the vision that drives them. On the contrary, it is based on input from the students and

assessors that experienced it, following a bottom-up approach to discuss design assessment methods.

Context

The MDD is a one-year programme that enables students to develop their design competences, especially the ability to work in interdisciplinary/multicultural teams on complex projects. In the Netherlands, design courses are offered by different institutions, including technical universities, art academies, and universities of applied sciences. Until recently, Dutch universities of applied sciences (UAS) could only offer practice-based education comparable to a bachelor level. This is an early example of a master's programme at a UAS, and the first one in this faculty, existing since 2017.

As an M.Sc. programme, the MDD is aligned with level 7 of the European Qualification Framework (EQF 7) and its Dutch counterpart (NLQF 7). The level's descriptors are articulated in a matrix of design-specific competences (Framing & Strategizing; Reflection & Awareness; Concepting & Ideation; Creating & Crafting; Self-Directed Learning), each divided in three indicators (see rubric in Appendix 1).

To achieve the competence profile required for graduating with a M.Sc., MDD students work in teams on three client projects that grow in length as the academic year advances (5, 8, and 14 weeks). They share project progress with peers in critique sessions chaired by the staff. Moreover, they are encouraged to pick up other self-directed projects if they wish. Four different tracks support the studio practice, namely Creation, Literacy, Research, and Strategy. These tracks include readings, lectures, workshops, and non-summative assignments and run in parallel to the client projects.

Summative assessments are the formal moments of evaluation in the MDD, and they take place twice per academic year: midterm (at the end of the first semester) and finals (at the end of the second semester), they award 30 European Credits (EC) each. Students hand in two deliverables in advance: (a) a process book including selected design work and (b) a reflection document explaining how this work matches the competence rubric. The selected work may include client projects, personal projects, and the assignments proposed in the different tracks. After considering these documents, a panel including three assessors – at least two of which are lecturers of the programme – interview each student individually for one hour. Building on the documents submitted, students can refer to any activity conducted while enrolled in the MDD programme to show how they meet the indicators in the rubric. After the interview, the student receives a grade calculated on the basis of the competences in the rubric, and qualitative feedback including impressions of the panel on the student's work and advice on future steps.

While developing the programme, this format was preferred over other ways of assessing studio-based education, seeking alignment with the programme's philosophy. In connection with the M.Sc. diploma offered, the MDD prioritises a focus on process rather than outcomes. Moreover, it aims at fostering critical reflection

emerging from practice rather than separating theory from design activity. In line with the previous points, the aesthetic quality or visual refinement of design solutions receives less attention than the understanding of the social, environmental, or ethical implications of their work. Lastly, it promotes independence and the crafting of an individual professional profile through self-directed learning. For example, having smaller exams at the end of each course could make the MDD less practical, as students would be tested on theory. Alternatively, grading the three projects that students do for external stakeholders would disincentivise students from working on self-initiated projects, thus reducing the emphasis on self-directed learning.

Practicalities and regulations aside, in this chapter, we would like to reflect on the extent to which this format responds to the purposes with which it was designed. We are aware that this is not a common format for design assessments, and believe that our own reflection (graduates', assessors', and the authors') will be of value for others intending to tackle challenges in design studio assessments.

Method

We designed two separate online surveys for former students and assessors, these were distributed across all relevant respondents. The aim of the survey was to understand how they regard MDD assessment methods when compared to other methods they have experienced within design education. Respondents not reacting to the questions addressing this issue specifically in the form are not considered in the qualitative analysis that appears later in the chapter. This includes assessors that did not have experience in this role in other programmes. We received 27 relevant responses from former students (the total number alumni is 117) and eight from former assessors. The responses were analysed by identifying differences and similarities with assessment methods practiced in other programmes, and advantages and disadvantages in relation to MDD methods according to respondents.

Results

The 27 former students completing the questionnaire are between 23 and 35 years old. They come from a variety of countries within and outside Europe. Most of them are currently living and working in the Netherlands. They work as designers in companies ranging from small design agencies and studios to big multinational consultancies. Five respondents are self-employed, another two are working in education, and yet another two are not working at the moment. Half of these respondents were students of the latest cohort (2020–2021), while the other half studied during the three previous academic years. Most of them followed design programmes for their bachelor degrees, in a variety of universities and countries.

The eight assessors were all active at MDD during the previous academic year (2020–2021), and some of them had been in that role for a longer time. They previously assessed design students in several programmes and institutions within and outside Europe.

The data provided by respondents confirms that the assessment format at MDD is different to other design education programmes in several aspects, with specific advantages and disadvantages over other methods. The main differences highlighted in the surveys are mentioned next.

Unification of Assessments

All graduates (except two respondents who do not describe or recall their bachelors' assessments) mention unification of assessments as a main difference with their bachelors. While in their bachelors, they were assessed separately in each course or project (for instance, for a certain number of credits) and at MDD, the assessments are fairly independent from the different courses. Students receive feedback from lecturers and coaches, and they use the work produced during these courses for assessments. However, they are not assessed by lecturers on their process or result within each course. This means that the design work produced in projects is only considered for assessment in relation to the programme's rubric (discussed in the next section).

As an example of this difference, one respondent explains that during their Graphic Design bachelor in Latin America, they were "usually assessed with grades via projects or exams. For more practical courses we would deliver a project. While in more theoretical courses we would take an exam or submit reports". Another respondent that graduated from a European B.A. in Communication Design had "three kinds of courses/classes with different kinds of assessments" including tests or written assignments for theoretical courses and practical design courses assessed by lectures based on design outcomes.

The unification of assessments seems to be particular in relation to other master level programmes, too. Five respondents of the assessors' survey had previously taken a similar role in other masters (in the Netherlands and abroad), and they all mention this difference.

Respondents list a variety of advantages and disadvantages for the unification of assessments, summarised here:

Advantages of the Unification of Assessments

- Time saving, and an opportunity to align expectations for staff.
- Holistic and based on individual personal/professional profile of students.
- Focused on earned skills rather than the output of students' work.
- Gives students an opportunity to look back to their past work, consider their present position, and plan their next steps accordingly.

Disadvantages of the Unification of Assessments

- It is a hard and stressful experience, especially for students used to being assessed based on the "quality" of specific design output, they feel unsure of what is expected.

- It can be frustrating for students to describe what they did in a past project for assessments when they no longer have the opportunity to change it.
- Failing an assessment can be painful when there are only two assessment moments in the whole master's programme. More frequent assessment helps to steer actions along the way in order to pass.

Use of (Integrated) Rubrics and Indicators for Expected Competencies

Some of the programmes previously experienced by respondents used rubrics and explicit competences in their assessment process. Others not. For instance, a graduate that completed a bachelor of arts in the Netherlands felt that "it was a relief to finally know what the parameters were and what was expected of students. This I had never experienced during my B.A." In line with the previous section on the unification of assessments, the programmes using rubrics tend to use separate rubrics for their courses or final assignment/thesis. Another respondent recalls from their bachelor of science in the Netherlands that "for each subject we had competences which we needed to fulfil. These were communicated to us in advance".

What is particular in MDD assessments is that there is a single rubric for the whole programme, which integrates all relevant competences across subjects. Respondents react differently to this method. Some appreciate the transfer of tacit knowledge from 'master to apprentice' and deal well with the implicit rules that guide 'good design'. These tend to regard the rubric as an unnecessary bureaucratic tool. Others (like in the quote opening this section) appreciate the explicit nature of rubrics. Overall, respondents point to the following advantages and disadvantages of an integrated rubric:

Advantages of an Integrated Rubric

- The rubric guides the learning process, students work considering what will be expected from them during assessments.
- Clarity in what is considered good work by the programme, for example, that projects are expected to include ethical considerations.
- The rubric separates grading from teacher-student relations, avoiding favouritism.

Disadvantages of an Integrated Rubric

- Difficult to understand what is expected from students, especially those that had not been evaluated with the use of rubrics before.
- The rubrics give the impression of impartiality, but the grades assigned to each competence depend on the interpretation of assessors.

Importance, Format, and Content of the Reflection Document

The survey results confirm that the reflection document is quite particular of this programme. This is one of the two deliverables requested to students for their assessments, next to a selection of their design work organised in a process book. The

outline of the reflection document matches the rubric. Students refer to their design work in the process book to explain how it matches, one by one, the required indicators. These reflections are later discussed in an individual interview, the grading and qualitative feedback are a result of this process.

One assessor referred to MDD assessments as one where students "demonstrate their capability" rather than "displaying their ability", the latter describing other creative programmes where this respondent has a similar role. A European graduate with a background in arts highlights that "for the first time during my studies, I was more focused on the skills I earned, rather than the quality of my work. At first, it completely did not make sense to me, but then I thought it was really interesting to encourage my personal evolution as a designer".

The MDD staff's choice to translate design 'quality' into competences regarding the breadth of the creative process, or the acknowledgement of the social context of projects in a written document is controversial, and some graduates felt strongly about it. "In my bachelor's, I was assessed on the actual (design) work I did and the quality of it, while the process was also important. At the MDD, the quality of the work was not of interest to anyone. As someone who has seen the quality of work delivered, I find this less fair and quite far away from the professional design world". Strong opinions emerged also on the other end, with some graduates acknowledging the influence of the reflection document in their learning experience and professional path: "A lot of my 'a-ha' moments for the year came in the 2nd semester assessment. Tying my projects together under one measure made me make deeper connections". Another graduate stated that putting together the reflection document "was insightful and gave me the professional self-awareness I had been lacking before. I learned a lot about how I work; my default role in a team and my strengths/weaknesses as a teammate and as an individual designer".

Overall, respondents point to the following advantages and disadvantages of the reflection document:

Advantages of the Reflection Document

- It promotes critical and reflective practitioners.
- It opens a path to become a better professional over time. Students are assessed on their ability to grow, they are not 'tied' to the work.
- It trains designers to clearly explain the rationale behind their decisions.

Disadvantages of the Reflection Document

- More useful for those pursuing a research focused career.
- It does not address the visual aspect of design quality.
- Disadvantage for students with reading and writing disabilities and non-English speakers.
- Can be frustrating to prepare and/or difficult to experience, as they are placed in a vulnerable position to reflect honestly on their own work (including its flaws) in front of others.

Freedom in Formats and Deliverables to Show Design Work, and in the Methods to Approach a Design Challenge

This aspect is less frequently mentioned by respondents in the survey, as the questionnaire did not address it specifically. However, a few respondents referred to this as a difference with other design programmes. There are no disadvantages mentioned, although freedom in the format of deliverables could be linked to lack of attention to visual aspects mentioned in previous sections. Positive statements about the freedom of formats include that of a graduate came from a European creative bachelor of arts student: "the MDD provides more freedom in approaching an assignment, making yourself more critical about what to include than on a bachelors. This positively affects my professional profile as tasks are not always as straightforward as in the academic system". Another graduate with a Dutch bachelor of science in Communication and Media Design stated that this freedom made them "realize where my true passions were and helped me be able to present what kind of designer I am (or aspired to be)".

Discussion

Building on the four characteristics of MDD assessments as described by respondents, and the advantages and disadvantages mentioned by them, in this section, we reflect on how the methods used to respond to the intentions for their development.

In our view, these methods help balancing studio-based education with university culture in a M.Sc. context. They are a way to navigate the challenges mentioned in literature and discussed in the introduction of this chapter. They also respond to the specific characteristics of our education system and university policy, and our choice to be open to candidates from all disciplinary backgrounds. Coming back to the literature, some of the challenges of studio-based education in a university context mentioned by scholars are addressed by this method in the following ways:

Obscurity in Studio-Based Assessments, with Problems in Terms of Reliability, Validity, and Transparency (Karahanoğlu et al., 2019)

The use of rubrics communicated to students at the beginning of the academic year, a practice that is becoming more common in design education, addresses this point. Integrating all staff input into a single rubric, and, therefore, two overall assessment moments along the year, helps to align the expectations of lectures and management and enables a holistic assessment of students considering their individual profiles. A point of attention here is the language used in rubrics, which many students find unclear, adding insecurity to the already stressful experience of being assessed. Although every year we run an iteration of the indicators together with all lecturers for continuous improvement, we do not ask input from students in this process. We see a clear opportunity for improvement here.

Isolation and Marginalisation of Creative Disciplines from the Other Fields (Wang, 2010)

The focus on reflection rather than on design artifacts for assessments, and the possibility of using group work as evidence, allows students with diverse disciplinary backgrounds to join the programme and potentially succeed during assessments. Although most of respondents to the graduates' survey had followed a design bachelor, that is not the case in the whole MDD alumni community, which is more varied.

Being assessed on the basis of text rather than visual elements is controversial and unexpected by some students. A point for improvement here is clearer communication to applicants. We promise students that they will upgrade their design skills to the next level during the programme, but we could be more explicit in what is meant. Better communicating what is good design in this programme is vital. Moreover, clarifying that we rely on self-directed learning for technical and visual skills, while focusing on more analytical aspects of design practice in the assessments should be made clearer to students. This is our way to promote professional development over time, following the principles of sustainable assessments (Boud & Soler, 2016).

Superficiality in the Understanding of Problems, Treating Its Symptoms Rather than Its Causes (Meyer & Norman, 2020)

Assessments drive learning, therefore, competences addressing ethical aspects of design, the acknowledgement of complexity in the context of projects, and the extent to which design decisions are based on reliable evidence in the rubric (and the self-reflective nature of assessments as a whole) promote a specific mindset when approaching client projects' briefs. We praise the learning-by-doing process that develops in studio practice, and the briefs bring a sense on real-world challenges that is much appreciated (Axelsson et al., 2006; Taylor & McCormack, 2004). However, these briefs do not always contemplate the aspects listed in this chapter, and we see the rubric as a balancing tool to ensure that they are addressed.

Some survey respondents saw a gap between the content of the rubric and the professional field, where, according to them, analytical skills are given a second place to technical knowledge and visual literacy. Still, we like to think of education as a practice that does not only provide businesses with the human resources they need, but also actively shapes practice in the professional field in a meaningful direction.



Support Material

Appendix 1 of this chapter can be found in the online Support Materials for this book: www.routledge.com/9781032835549

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